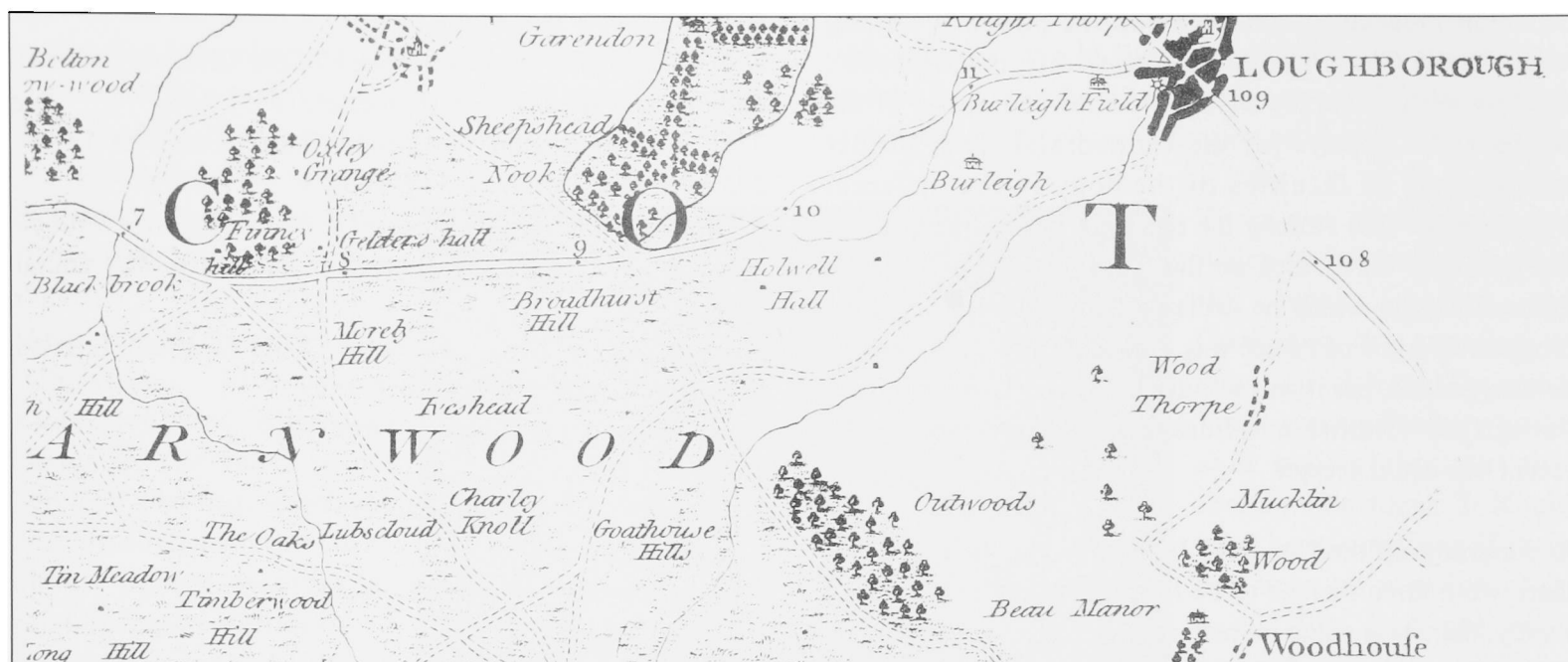


Whetstones and Goats: the unexpected!

David Ramsey



Charnwood Forest as seen by the map maker John Prior in 1777. Goathouse Hill is marked to the west of the Outwoods. (With acknowledgement to Leicestershire in 1777, and edition of John Prior's map of Leicestershire with an introduction and commentary by members of the Leicestershire Industrial History Society, edited by J. D. Welding, LLIS, 1984).

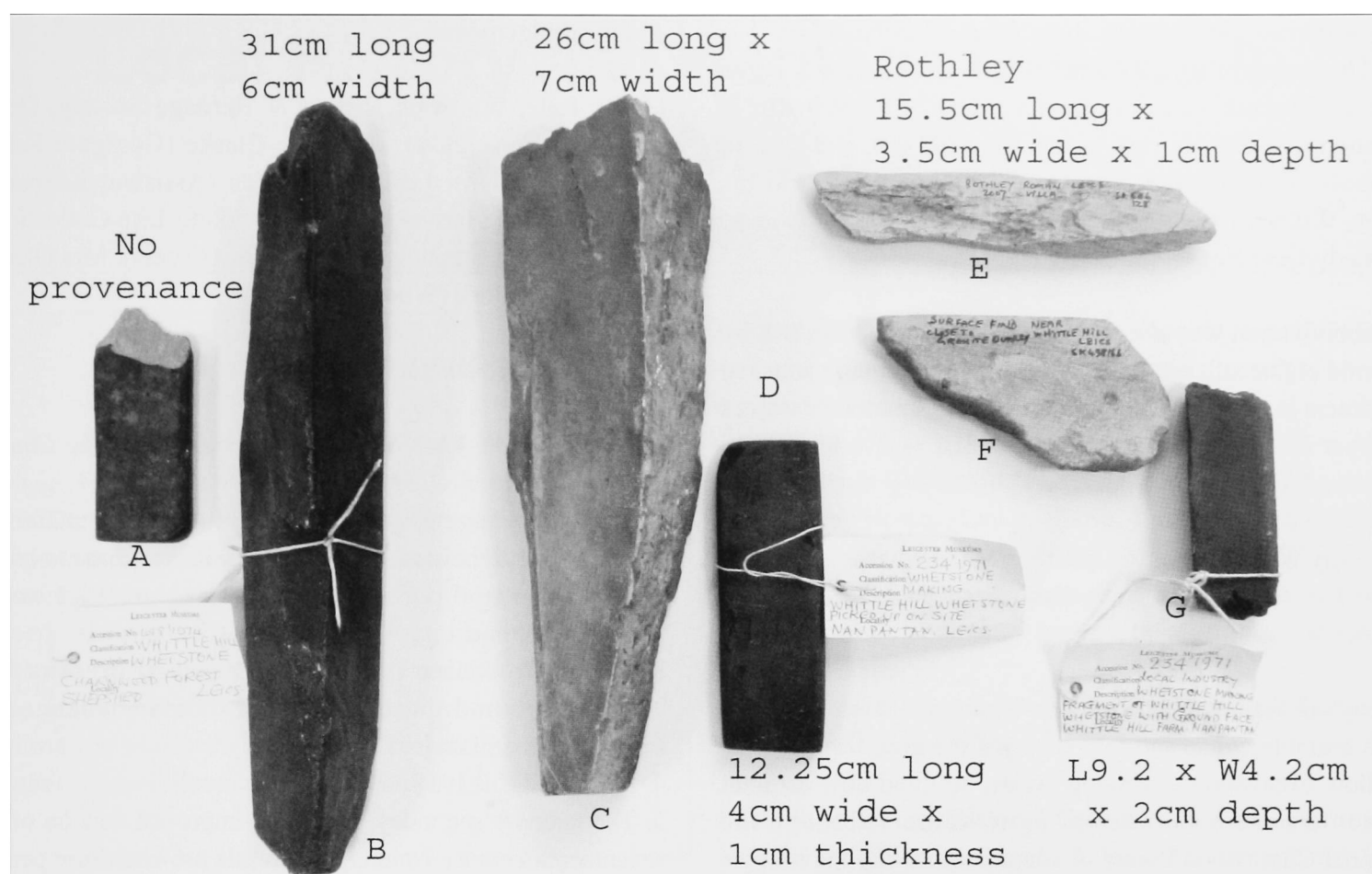
Whilst researching the history of whetstones in Leicestershire, an unexpected connection was found between a whetstone quarry and a large-scale goat-keeping operation. This article brings together this unlikely combination in north-west Leicestershire, focussing on Whittle's Warren, formerly Goat House Hill, near to Charley in the Charnwood Forest area of the county.

Historical evidence for the quarrying of whetstones at Whittle's Warren can be found in Nichols, who, writing at the end of the eighteenth century, refers to the quarries on Goat House Hill as producing sharpening stones, adding that the stones were most excellent for sharpening razors and penknives, and sold for two pence an ounce at Birmingham, Sheffield and Wolverhampton. (1) Possessing fine honing qualities, the Goat House Hill Stones, (or Charley oil stones), were eminently suitable for the sharpening of surgical knives.

Today, there are surviving examples of whetstones in the Leicestershire County Collection, whilst recent enquiries placed in both the *Leicestershire Archaeological & Historical Society Newsletter* and the *Leicestershire Industrial History Newsletter* requesting more information about the Leicestershire whetstones have also resulted in more examples coming to light including two new types: a large boxed honing stone suitable for workshop use and a smaller more portable type.

The stones from Goat House Hill and the surrounding outcrops were prepared for sale locally. Using Nichols as a guide, this activity most likely pre-dates 1785, whilst the occupational data on census records indicate an end date of c.1890. (2) During the period between 1851 and 1861, the manufacture of whetstones appears to have been a true cottage industry, with a few of the families and their locations being known, for example, at Coleorton, where Jess and Elizabeth Crosen, along with Joseph and Thomas Else, were preparing the stone for sale at Rotten Row (3), whilst Richard and William Stacey were doing the same at Thringstone. These villages, although some distance from Whittle Hill, are connected by the Thringstone geological fault which joins Thringstone, Abbots Oak, Green Hill, Whitwick and Whittle Hill along a thin fault line from which the whetstone rock extruded at intermittent points.

Finding the stone outcrops was not that easily done and once the sources around the Thringstone area failed to produce good stone, the workers turned to elsewhere including Whittle Hill, although when Benjamin Rose and Thomas Tracey tried to replenish their stocks of material from the Whittle Hillside they were caught with the stone and appeared at the Loughborough Petty Sessions in February 1836. Both men were sentenced to five months for larceny.



Whetstones A, B, D & G are from the Leicestershire County collection. The three stones with provenance B, D & G are strongly stained with oil and dust and varying in shape size. The cleaner stones C, E & F are from the author's collection: C is from the Whittle Hill spoil heap, E from the Roman villa site at Rothley and F is a surface find near Roe's Plantation northwest of Whittle Hill. (E & F were later deemed to be not true whetstones and most likely from the Beacon/Buck Hill/Outwoods area two miles south east of Whittle Hill).



Fragments of whetstone on the old spoil heap at Whittle Hill.

Whilst searching for earlier mentions of whetstones at Whittle Hill, an estate document from the Herrick collection of rents and leases dated 1560 contained an unexpected surprise – 100 goats at the Goat house on Whittle Hill but no

mention of either the stone, or the quarries. The goats were at this time in the custody of one Ralph Piggot who received a significant yearly allowance for keeping them. (4) Why the Beaumanor Estate would require one hundred goats on the payroll is not easily understood. Apart from milk, meat and the hair to make ropes (goat hair was thought resistant to the effects of sea water and sought for ships ropes), the numbers and associated expense appears out of proportion to the Estate requirements unless there were commercial sales. (5)

The Herrick estate papers also give names to the Goat House Hill's inhabitants in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. From these records we hear in 1638 of an Isabel and Robert Broadhurst of the Goat House who were fined for not frequenting their Parish Church at Shepshed. (6) The family name 'Whittle' appears to have become firmly attached to Goat House Hill during the seventeenth century as indicated in the 1664 Hearth Tax which show a John Whittle in the Goat house with 2 hearths, whilst William Whittle of Beaumanor is also mentioned in papers during this same period (7), and a surviving will of February 1672 expands the Whittle family tree: *To my son Robert Whittle my land at Rothley and to my wife Elizabeth my lands and goods for life. To my brother, Thomas Sheffield - my house in Rothley. My brother, Francis Sheffield to be overseer.*

The witnesses: Anne Peale Anne Easby & John Whinyates.

(8) The last mention of a Whittle at the Goat House is in the late eighteenth century, firstly when John Whittle is mentioned in the Herrick papers for 1793 (9), and then in Nichols who adds the passing of William Whittle to his notes, William having died in 1796 a resident at the warren, formerly Goat House, for nearly eighty years.

A rabbit warren was also well established at Whittle Hill by the mid eighteenth century and is recorded as being attacked by rioters in 1748. At the same time Lord Stamford's warren a short distance away at Hunt's Hill was completely destroyed. (10)

Precisely when the honing qualities of the whetstones on the Goat House Hill site were discovered however, remains unknown.

Today the shallow quarry sites at Whittle Hill are overgrown with bramble, gorse and fern covering the greater part of the shallow excavations, bringing vividly to mind how difficult it would have been attempting to venture through the original Charnwood Forest. A sound reason why the triangle of roads, A6 Leicester to Loughborough, A512 Loughborough to Ashby, and the A50, later the Leicester, Whitwick and Swannington roads defined the earlier limits of the Forest's spread for so many years.

The author will be pleased to hear from anyone who thinks they may have a Leicestershire whetstone either in their garden shed or elsewhere.

Acknowledgements:

Lesley Hale, Whitwick History & Heritage Society, Denis Baker (Swannington), Grahame Clarke (Goatgate Farm, Newbold Verdon), Jeanette Ovenden (Assistant Keeper at ROLLR), Fred Hartley (Curator, Working Life Collection), Joanna Herbert-Stepney and B. Morrit (Access), Mrs Gladys Poole, Owen York (Whetstones).

References and Notes:

1. John Nichols, *The History and Antiquities of the County of Leicester (1795 – 1811)*.
2. Printed packaging, catalogues and advertising materials connected with the stones have so far failed to come to hand, so any reader who can add to the present knowledge would be most welcome.
3. Rotten Row lies in the fields west of present day Thringstone and due to various boundary changes is sometimes found under Coleorton.
4. ROLLR: DG9/1918.
5. The goat we see today is a much-improved version of its seventeenth century counterpart. In this pre-enclosure period oversight and vigilance over the herd would have been paramount as opportunist thieves roamed far and wide in the area as the Loughborough Petty Sessions books clearly show.
6. ROLLR: DG 9/527.
7. ROLLR: DG20 (Grey Family) DE311/43/2.
8. ROLLR: Leicester 3/146.
9. ROLLR: DG5/470.
10. D. A. Ramsey, *Was there a village called Bradgate?* (1998).

In response to the appeal for original Charley whetstones (LAHS Newsletter No: 77 Spring 2008) these fine examples have been loaned to the author by a LAHS member. 'B'- has sound Leicestershire provenance. 'A'- History unknown but based on colour and texture, almost certainly from the same geological source. The pine box containing 'B' has no markings – just two proud nails in the lid help to locate the lid squarely onto the base.

